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UMass Memorial Health's struggles worsen

Medicaid cuts likely to mean loss of some services

By Marin Wolf

GLOBE STAFF

For UMass Memorial Health, a brutal year looks like it's only going to get worse.

Weighed down by an \$86 million operating loss over the first half of fiscal year 2025, the huge health system based in Worcester has been slowly chipping away at services provided by its community-based provider. It's already shut several

programs, including two primary care clinics and a substance use treatment center for teens, and will soon close a behavioral health program for adults in Fitchburg.

Its financial struggles are emblematic of a worrisome future for all of medical care in Massachusetts. Already hemmed in by rising costs and tight insurance reimbursements, health care providers in the state are expected to lose some \$3.5 billion in Medicaid payments.

With more than half of the hospitals in the state currently in the red, Alan Sager, a Boston University professor of health law, policy, and

management, said the Medicaid cuts will only compound the difficult financial decisions many are already facing.

"There will be program closures," Sager said. "There will be individual patients who don't get care because they lost coverage or because the program that served them was eliminated."

The dominant provider of medical care in Central Massachusetts, UMass Memorial treats some 500,000 patients a year, more than a quarter of them covered by Medicaid, the government health insurance for the poor and disabled. About one in 20 UMass Memorial

patients are uninsured, which means the health system often has to absorb the costs of treatment, adding to the financial strain.

Dr. Eric Dickson, the UMass Memorial chief executive, said the recent program closures were made in part to offset recent financial shortfalls, but also were driven by the impending cuts to Medicaid.

President Trump's signature tax and spending legislation will slash nearly \$1 trillion from Medicaid over the next 10 years, taking health insurance away from up to 16 million Americans, according to the nonpartisan Congressional Budget

UMASS MEMORIAL, Page A7

Putin has much to gain with summit

Talking to Trump is another step in thawing Russia's pariah status in the West

By Andrew Higgins and Nataliya Vasilyeva

NEW YORK TIMES

President Trump has spent the week setting the bar extremely low for his high-stakes US-Russian summit Friday in Alaska. Hardly anyone expects

NEWS ANALYSIS him to make much progress in halting the fighting between Russia and Ukraine, given how far apart their views of the war are.

But those two warring countries do seem to agree on at least one thing. Merely meeting with Trump is a big win for President Vladimir Putin, bringing the Russian leader out of a diplomatic deep freeze and giving him a chance to cajole the American president face-to-face.

"Putin's visit to the USA means the total collapse of the whole concept of isolating Russia. Total collapse," Kremlin-controlled television crowed after news of the hastily arranged summit broke last weekend.

For Russia, "this is a breakthrough even if they don't agree on much," said Sergei Mikhayev, a pro-war Russian political scientist who is a mainstay of state television.

President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine, iced out of the Alaska talks about his own country's future, has come to the same conclusion, telling reporters Tuesday: "Putin will win in this. Because he

MEETING, Page A6

Auditor finds widespread issues at pot commission

By Nick Stoico

GLOBE STAFF

and Stella Tannenbaum and Yogev Toby

GLOBE CORRESPONDENTS

An audit of the state's troubled Cannabis Control Commission found widespread mismanagement, violations of state regulations, and potential improprieties at the agency charged with regulating the marijuana industry in Massachusetts, Auditor Diana DiZoglio's office said Thursday.

The review, which examined operations at the commission from 2022 to 2024, cited a host of regulatory lapses. It determined that the agency failed to enforce regulations in a timely manner or maintain adequate internal controls.

The audit also raised concerns about transparency and fairness. It revealed "the appearance of potential favoritism and/or impropriety" as some cannabis businesses were required to pay fees "while others inexplicably did not need to do so," the office said.

The agency did not keep records of instances when fees were waived.

The audit also found that the commission

AUDIT, Page A10



WIN MCNAMEE/GETTY IMAGES

People at a homeless encampment near the Lincoln Memorial packed up their belongings Thursday after being notified that it would be removed, part of President Trump's campaign to clean up the city. The effort took root as National Guard troops watched over some of the city's most renowned landmarks. **A2.**

The Justice Department said it will seek the death penalty for a member of the cult-like Zizians group accused of killing a US Border Patrol agent in Vermont. **B1.**

A Superior Court judge granted a restraining order against two fired Market Basket executives, barring them from visiting stores, offices, and other supermarket facilities. **B5.**

Massachusetts has the fourth lowest homeownership rate for adults 25 to 34 in the country, and the picture isn't getting any brighter. **B5.**

Jarren Duran is unique in baseball — after most home games, he signs autographs for as long as it takes. **C1.**

Spike Lee's "Highest 2 Lowest" is one of the year's best films, writes Odie Henderson. **G1.**

'While we support Harvard standing up to the Trump administration, it's stolen valor to do so while exploiting its workers.'

ADAM SYCHLA, a bargaining committee member for the Harvard Academic Workers Union

Harvard unions say they're losing voice on nondiscrimination policies

By Diti Kohli and Aidan Ryan

GLOBE STAFF

As Harvard battles with the White House, it is tussling with campus unions over how much say they get on antidiscrimination policies for research assistants, post-docs, and professors.

Both the Harvard Academic Workers Union and Graduate Students Union said the university has ignored their calls for nondiscrimi-

nation provisions in the contracts. Instead, Harvard has said that discrimination complaints — on the basis of race or gender identity, for example — should be settled by university-wide policies, which Harvard can change at will.

Harvard and its unions have grappled over this issue before. The university instituted a campus-wide policy on nondiscrimination in fall 2023 after consultation with cam-

pus groups and unions.

A university spokesperson referred to a statement it released in June that said, "Our proposal is aligned with the University's position that the Non-Discrimination, Anti-Bullying, and Title IX policies are the appropriate processes for these concerns." The spokesperson declined to comment further on Thursday.

HARVARD, Page A7

Whoop defies FDA over blood pressure device

Keeps selling wearable despite regulation order

By Marin Wolf

GLOBE STAFF

The Food and Drug Administration has told Whoop that it must get its wearable blood pressure tool approved as a medical device, but the Boston tech company is refusing to submit it to the agency for regulation — and refusing to stop selling it.

Whoop makes a wristband that tracks the wearer's fitness and health, measuring indicators such as heart rate, heart rate variability, and sleep quality. The FDA considered the device a general wellness product not

subject to regulation until May, when Whoop introduced a feature that estimates the wearer's blood pressure.

Since then, the FDA has repeatedly told Whoop that the software tool, called Blood Pressure Insights, should be regulated as a medical device and meet the higher standards applied to medical-grade technologies. In the agency's most recent letter, sent in July, the FDA warned that continuing to distribute the device without regulatory approval violated federal law.

But in a response sent Aug. 4, Whoop rejected the FDA's assessment, saying the software didn't meet the definition of a medical device and the company would continue to offer the feature. The company, which shared the letter with the Globe, also argued

WHOOP, Page A10



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

ROOT, ROOT, ROUT — Braintree American began play in the Little League World Series on Thursday and had plenty of support back home (10-year-olds, from left, Max Verrill, Griffin Brew, and Zach Bosse) at a watch party at the SouthSide Tavern. The day went sour, though, as the team was crushed by Irmo, S.C., 13-0. Their run isn't over yet, however. **B1, C2.**

Wring out the old

Friday: Much less humid. High 73-78. Low 62-67.

Saturday: Beautiful. High 78-83. Low 65-70.

High tide: 4:14 a.m., 4:36 p.m. Sunrise: 5:51 Sunset: 7:45

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